

Political powerhouse

Johnson was a product of the Texas Hill Country. His father, a farmer and businessman, had sat in the Texas state legislature. Johnson embarked on a career in politics, rising through a combination of hard work and a talent for ruthless political maneuvering. Aged 28, he entered Congress as a New Deal Democrat and 10 years later was elected a Senator, albeit amid accusations of vote rigging. The Senate provided an ideal arena for his talents as a political fixer; he was an outstandingly successful leader of the Democratic majority from 1955, driving controversial legislation through Congress. His ability to induce politicians to change their votes—by a mixture of brow-beating, arm-twisting, and favors—became legendary.

Johnson aspired to be the Democratic presidential candidate in 1960, but his hopes were flattened by the tidal wave of support for John F. Kennedy. Although the sophisticates of the Kennedy camp were inclined to disparage Johnson, with his blunt Texan manner and his reputation for unscrupulous wheeler-dealing, he was nonetheless invited to run as vice-president to secure the Southern vote. Once in office, however, the Kennedy inner circle was reluctant to allow Johnson any significant role. Instead, he carved out areas in which his drive could express itself, notably civil rights and the fledgling space program.



Johnson on civil rights

President Johnson meets civil rights leaders at the White House on August 6, 1965, the day the Voting Rights Act, prohibiting racial discrimination in voting, was signed into law.

Taking the reins

Johnson was two cars behind Kennedy in Dallas when the president was shot. Sworn in aboard Air Force One that afternoon, he assumed the reins of power with confidence and dignity. Johnson's swift appointment of the Warren Commission—a week after the event—